Round 4, run 5: Erra and Išum – report

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Child session `Round4/Run5: Erra and Išum` (2026-10-24), started by the Round 4 orchestrator. Model: Opus 5.5 for the coordinator and the one translator sub-agent (no cheaper model used).

Done

- **Erra and Išum, Tablet I: all 191 lines** (eBL `L/1/5`, Standard Babylonian I, ed. E. Jiménez, rev. Mitto, Földi, Hätinen, Rozzi), as **project 5 of the netherworld corpus** `העולם-התחתון/5-ארה-ואישום/`:
  - `annotated.rtl.md` (191 entries with 8 sections; 7 footnotes); פירוק / תרגומים / הקבלה / הערות;
  - `translation.rtl.md` (generated by `netherworld_tools.py build ER`) with `translation--intro.rtl.md`;
  - `project.md` (scope, decisions 1–24, proposals, the parallels index: 190 rows);
  - the print stub `הדפסה/העולם-התחתון/5-ארה-ואישום.rtl.md`.
- **Tablets II–V were not translated: they do not exist in the edition yet.** eBL lists chapters II–V with their manuscripts (13, 14, 13 and 20) but no lines ("An edition … will be uploaded in the course of 2025/2026"). The plan row's "now all five tablets" was not true of the published edition. Details:
  - the manuscripts' Fragmentarium records carry no transliteration;
  - ORACC is unreachable from the cloud;
  - Cagni 1969 / 1970 are © and lending-only on archive.org.

  Recorded in `sources/_records-only--Erra-and-Ishum-II-V/README.md`, the plan row, STATUS and `project.md`, with the re-check command.
- **Corpus decision:** the netherworld corpus, not a new one. Erra is Nergal's other name (project 3), and the corpus's tool, renderings and formulas carried over. A new corpus for one tablet was not worth its set-up.

- **Before the first line:**
  - `renderings.md` §12 (names, ~90 key terms, 23 formulas, reserved words, the fixed lines);
  - a precedent table of every lemma across the corpora;
  - `netherworld_tools.py` key `ER` (per-project gates and traps, formulas, and a fixed-lines check);
  - a skeleton annotated file with eBL's normalization in every entry;
  - a translator brief §6.
- **The shared passage:** Erra I 126–162 had already been translated (2026-10-16) in the flood corpus's flood references (§7).
  - Those 37 lines were revised to the rules fixed since then and copied into the new project.
  - The flood references were aligned to the same text: 28 lines in `annotated.rtl.md` and `translation.rtl.md`, their renderings rows, two parallels rows there and in the flood corpus's `parallels-index.md`, and a log line in their `project.md`.
  - `verify ER --strict` now checks that both copies stay identical.
- **The netherworld `parallels-index.md`:** regenerated (741 rows) with a "Key findings: Erra and Išum I" section.
- **Shared files** (once, at the end):
  - `STATUS.md`;
  - the plan row;
  - guidelines §5.2 (one rule line), §6.5 (four names) and §6.7 (an Erra bullet);
  - `history.md` (the run's account and a changelog line);
  - `sources-registry.md`;
  - `tools.md`.
- **Commits** on `main`: the setup `26ce39e` → part 1 `e8c3234` → part 2 → the shared lines `ccfcbd7` → the translation and index `ea8f8a1` → the shared files `8e04497` → the untracked translation files → this report.

Verification

- `netherworld_tools.py verify ER --strict`: **OK**, 191 entries. This covers coverage, the source lines, the reserved and gated strings, the traps, 27 ER formulas, the fixed lines against renderings §12.6 and against the flood references, and that the translation equals the `>` lines.
- `verify IS|IN|NE|GEN --strict`: **OK** after the tool changes. IN has two "same source, different Hebrew" notes it had before.
- `check_bible_quotes.py`: **0 problems** on `5-ארה-ואישום/*.rtl.md`, `project.md`, `renderings.md`, `parallels-index.md`, all `*/project.md` of the corpus, the flood references' `annotated.rtl.md` / `translation.rtl.md` / `project.md`, the guidelines, STATUS and history. The translator printed every verse first.

- **The gates on the pre-set lines** (§5.2) caught three errors before any drafting:
  - `שבים` "in the sea" tripped the `שוב` gate;
  - an unvocalized `שמש`;
  - the reserved `תחתית` ("the lower millstone", which became `אבן השכב`).
- **Review:** the translator did three review passes over each part and a final consistency pass over 1–191. I read all 191 `>` lines myself and diffed the §12 rows against the drafted lines (the ★ rule); five rows were changed by the translator, each with a reason, and merged (§12.7).
- `sources_sync.py fetch`: done. Erra-SB-I matches the manifest; the failures are the known web.archive.org items.

Key findings

For the Bible

- **Ex 12:13, 23.**
  - Išum "walks in the night" and "guides the lad and the girl in safety" (21–22); he "is a door: before them (the Seven) he is shut" (27).
  - In Exodus the blood-marked door keeps out the destroyer; here the merciful god himself is the door.
  - The poem was copied onto house amulets. The Aššur amulet Ist-A 153 and the Tarbiṣu amulet IM 95180 are among Tablet I's manuscripts, and Tarbiṣu has 28–30 and 152–176. The amulets did in Assyrian houses what the blood does in Ex 12.
- **Deut 32:24, 33 in cognates.**
  - The seventh of the Seven is loaded with *imat bašmi* (38) = `חֲמַת פְּתָן`: both are the Song of Moses' venom words. Erra's weapons smear themselves with *imat mūti* (7).
  - Deut 32:23–25's arsenal belongs to the Seven: the arrows *uṣṣu* (90) `חֵץ` and the sword (12).
  - Išum's "lad and girl in safety" (22) reverses Deut 32:25.
- **Gen 6:1–4.**
  - Anu mates with Earth, and seven warrior gods are born and named (28–29; *ittabi zikiršun* ↔ Gen 5:2), with no sin and no punishment.
  - The seven sages, the gods' craftsmen, were "sent down" to the Apsû and never brought up (147, 162).
- **Deut 31:17–18 as cosmology.**
  - Marduk rose from his seat once, and the flood came: "the seam of heaven and earth" tore (132–137).
  - If he rises again, the waters, the darkness and the netherworld rise (170–177).
  - Divine absence here is a physical unravelling of the world; Gen 9:11 promises the opposite.

- **The plea and the litany.**
  - Išum to the angry Erra: "Why have you plotted evil … will you not turn back?" (102–103) ↔ Gen 50:20 and Ex 32:12 שׁוּב מֵחֳרוֹן אַפֶּךָ.
  - "Let them hear and tremble" (62–74) follows Ex 15:14–16 step by step.
- **Smaller contacts:**
  - the sleeping god (16–20; Ps 44:24, 78:65; 1 Kgs 18:27);
  - *ṭēma šakānu* = Aramaic שָׂם טְעֵם (31; Ezra 5:13);
  - *kamān tumri* ~ כַּוָּנִים (57; Jer 7:18);
  - *tamlû* (59) מְלֹוא;
  - the rusted sword "for lack of slaughter" (91; Ezek 21:14–16);
  - *pānī šakānu* (124; 2 Kgs 12:18);
  - "I am the standard" נֵס (114; Ex 17:15);
  - the gods "made to crouch" (*ušarbaṣa*) at Marduk's gate (189; Gen 4:7 3:24 ,רֹבֵץ);
  - the wooden statue made by craftsmen as "the flesh of the gods" (150–162), against the prophets' mockery (Isa 40:20; Jer 10:3, 9).
- **Inside Akkadian literature:**
  - 172 repeats Gilg. XI 107 almost word for word;
  - 187 repeats Enkidu's death-dream (Gilg. VII 183);
  - 175 echoes Ištar's threat to raise the dead;
  - the noise that keeps the gods awake (41, 73, 82) is Atra-ḫasīs's, in the same Hebrew.

For the ancient mind

- The war god who cannot rest, caught between a tired body and a heart that wants battle. He makes love with Mami, using the idiom of Enkidu and Šamḫat.
- The Seven are Erra's weapons (44), which is why he speaks to his weapons and to them in one breath.
- The soldiers' ethos (47–59): the city is for old men and babies, and ash-cake is better than palace bread.
- The gods need quiet (82).
- Weapons rot unused (87–91).
- Erra's self-praise makes him the harmful force in every part of the world (109–118).
- The cult statue is the god's body: its "flesh", its craftsmen, the sages who purify it.
- The closing trick: Erra offers to guard the world, so that its king will leave it.

Decisions taken (minor, by me)

- **Scope:** Tablet I only. II–V are recorded as waiting for eBL. I took no quick win in their place (the Poor Man of Nippur, L/1/11, 161 lines, is on eBL: a candidate for the parent).
- **Corpus:** project 5 of העולם-התחתון/.

- **Renderings §12 and its merges (§12.7)**, among them:
  - *imtu* חֵמָה and *bašmu* פֶּתֶן [cognates];
  - *mātu* and *erṣetu* both אֶרֶץ, as in every Akkadian corpus;
  - *šubtu* מוֹשָׁב;
  - *šasû* הִצְעִיק (קָרָא stays *nabû*'s);
  - *šiknāt napišti* בַּעֲלֵי הַנֶּפֶשׁ;
  - Irkalla אִירְכַּלָּה (the corpus form);
  - and the translator's five departures (*šaḫātu* נרתע, *ṭūdu* נתיב, *ulmu* מגזרה, the masculine stative of 27, *zikru* in 29).
- **The shared lines 126–162:** 28 revised in both corpora. I changed my own first plan on two points to keep the flood corpus's formulas: *abūba šakānu* וחוללתי מבול, and *ummânu* הָאֻמָּנִים.
- **Tool:** project-specific gates and traps (`RESERVED_KEY` / `TRAPS_KEY`), so that Erra's reserved words cannot break the finished projects. The חמה gate was fixed (it had matched מלחמה).

Questions for the user

None that only the user can answer. One item for the orchestrator: whether to fill this run's slot with a quick win (the Poor Man of Nippur, 161 lines, eBL `L/1/11`), since Erra II–V cannot be done yet.

Problems and skipped items

- **Erra II–V** (~480 lines): no open edition. Re-check eBL each round (`python3 -I tools/ebl_fetch.py L 1 5 "Standard Babylonian" II sources/eBL/Erra-SB-II`). The plan's Torah focus lies mostly there: Marduk's absence and Erra's rule (II–III), Išum's march (IV), and the amulet blessing (V 49–61, ↔ Ex 12:7, Deut 6:9). Tablet I covered Ex 12:23, Deut 32:24–25, 33, Gen 6:4 and the absence motif.
- **Found on the way, not fixed:** four NE formulas in `netherworld_tools.py` (Kakka through the gates, the 7-day refrain, "raise the dead", *zikar u sinniš*) match no NE source line, so they check nothing (`tools.md`). Left for the next netherworld session.
- A slip of mine, caught and fixed: the new `translation*.rtl.md` files were missed by a `git commit -- <dir>` (untracked files). They were committed separately.
- No quota stop. The status was a `seven_day` `allowed_warning` all run, on a Saturday (UTC), so it was ignored under the user's rule.

Cross-corpus splits left for the lead

1. ***imtu* "venom":** חֵמָה [cognate] here (and Ugaritic *ḥmt* חמה), against Enūma eliš and Maqlû אֶרֶס. The cognate rule suggests moving EE and Maqlû. Hesiod's חמה ("wrath", Greek) is only a homograph.

2. ***ummânu*:** the flood corpus and Erra אֻמָּן, against Gudea's Sumerian *um-mi-a* אָמָּן (temple corpus). One spelling should win.
3. ***šubtu*:** מוֹשָׁב here (Enūma eliš), against the Gilgameš formula *šubat irkalla* משכן אירכלה in IS / NE. Kept by formula; noted.
4. ***mātu* / *erṣetu*:** both אֶרֶץ, as in every Akkadian corpus. The netherworld Descents reserve הָאָרֶץ for the netherworld; in Erra I the netherworld is *erkallu* / *kurnugû* / *arallû*, so there is no clash inside this text.
5. ***ṣubātu*:** בגד here (141, 181), against GEN / Gilg. XII שִׂמְלָה.
6. ***emqu*** חכם shares the word with *apkallu* חכם; ***malku*** מלך shares it with *šarru*.
7. ***nādu* "waterskin"** נאד [cognate], against the Descent of Ištar's *ḫalziqqu* (99–98) נאד.
8. **The flood formula *abūba šakānu*** חולל מבול (flood corpus) is kept against *šakānu* = שָׂם (the creation rule). The rule could say that a formula wins.
9. **Checked with no split:**
   - Ugaritic: *bṯn* פֶּתֶן, *ḥṣ* חֵץ and *ḥmt* חמה are the same cognates.
   - Egyptian: no collision.
   - Hesiod: חמה is a homograph only.